

New WAVE

A reef built to contain erosion in Kovalam might turn out to be a bonanza for surfing enthusiasts

Artificial reefs are the latest thing internationally, and have come in for both severe criticism and praise. The one at Kovalam is India's first experiment with multi-purpose reefs and both the Tourism Department and surfing enthusiasts hope that besides erosion control, (supposedly the primary objective) the new reef will create waves throughout the year, making Kovalam a premium surfing location in India.

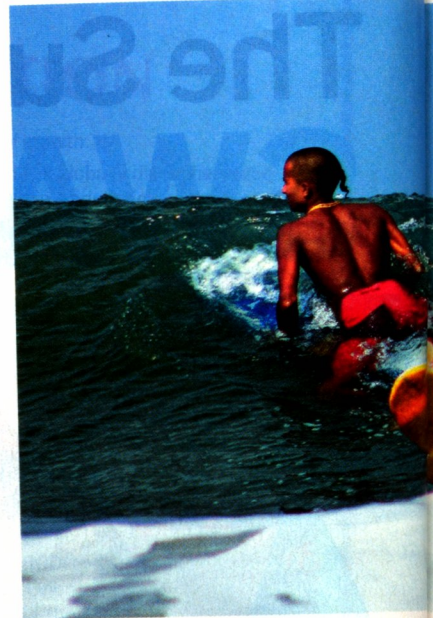
The reef was opened only recently and surfing enthusiasts are looking forward to seeing how it handles during the pre and post monsoon periods. It was constructed by a New Zealand company, ASR Ltd, which has made similar reefs (some of which are failures) around the world primarily to check erosion. But

surfing enthusiasts were taken by pleasant surprise at the quality of waves at the Kovalam reef. Says Daruka Das, manager, KMA, "We might not have 100 ft waves like what we've used to seeing in the movies in places like Hawaii. But the problem with California or Hawaii is that it is so crowded that there are 60-70 people fighting for every wave, whereas in India, the entire sea is yours and these are spots that every surfing enthusiast looks for."

Surfing aficionados are also thrilled at the quality of waves over the reef in India. Some feel it could well be the best wave an artificial reef has ever created and on the right swell are even looking forward to the possibility of Kovalam hosting an international surfing event in the near future.

THE KOVALAM BEACH

Courtesy: KERALA TOURISM



people who are always anxious to do something new and exciting. But after outsiders showed an interest, we started teaching them," says Narasingha of the pioneering effort. Joining the surfers from the ashram unflinchingly every week are Tushar Pathiyan and Ishita M. from nearby Mani'al. "I've been surfing with them for nearly two years now. I surf at the ashram beach every Sunday and in Mani'al every chance I get," says Ishita, who is perhaps India's first and only woman surfer. "I was hooked the first day and for the next three months, I was only worried about finding money to buy a board," says Pathiyan of his initiation.

The last year has seen a regular stream of surfing enthusiasts from America, Japan and Australia to the ashram not to mention Indians who are curious to experience what surfing is all about. The surfing retreat was a natural extension of the ashram and accommodates four to six guests who want to try their hand at it. "We have kept it to a minimum because we don't want it to become a hotel. This is primarily an ashram. That we surf is incidental," says ashram manager